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8. A price book would be great, especially for staples

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All the smart frugal shoppers keep price books, where they note down the best price they can get for any given item. That's been on my to-do list for, oh, half my life. But since I started shopping on the budget, at least I've been looking over my receipts at the end of the week and getting a good idea for my target prices for the things I buy the most: cereal, milk, cage-free eggs, chicken, and of course, produce.

This is actually a big change for me, because in my old, "shop as frugally as possible" mode, I just compared prices *in that store* and *on that day*. That is, I figured I needed at least three pounds of meat for the week, so I would buy the three cheapest meats available. Now that I'm aware that I can pay \$3 a pound or less for conventional meat and poultry, if there is nothing under \$6 in the store, I just don't buy meat that day. This may seem like a waste of time, since I'll have to hit a different store if we want any meat. But on the other hand, I spend a lot *less* time comparing "price per ounce" to find the absolute best value in the cooler.

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9. Just because the caviar's half-price doesn't mean it's affordable

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I used to bring all kinds of goodies back from club store runs—ready-to-heat organic mushroom ravioli, for instance. I figured since I knew it was a good deal, I barely had to glance at the price. But that doesn't work with a limited amount to spend each week, and this has been one of the key reasons the budget helps me spend less. Instead of worrying about getting the best possible deal for a given item, I think more about how to get a week's worth of nutritious and filling meals for my budget.

That means some delicacies are never going to come home with me, unless it's New Year's Eve or it's practically free after a coupon. It also means that I buy a lot more chicken than beef, and that I almost never buy juice or soda.

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10. Shopping frugally is worth the time

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A lot of my friends tell me they don't have time to be frugal. Actually, a friend who is unemployed and has no kids told me that, which kind of blew my mind. Personally, I sometimes worry that I'm spending too much